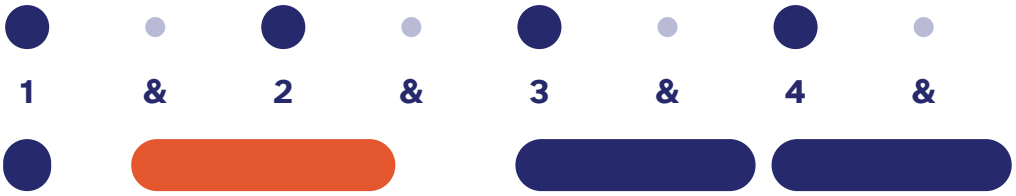
PART II · TIME · 7

Rhythm: off the beat

Now the fun part: rhythm that teases the beat. It only works if the beat underneath stays rock-steady.

THE SECRET

Keep the beat rock-steady and let the rhythm tease it.



starts on “&”, held over beat 2

A note between the beats

Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.



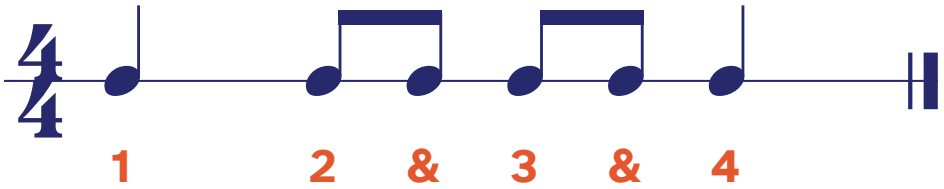
Written



Played

EXAMPLE 1

Which notes swing?



?

1. **Find the quaver pairs.** On which beats?
2. **Play each pair long–short:** “doo-ba”.
3. **What about the crotchets?**

Only the **pairs** (beats 2 and 3) swing; the crotchets and the beat underneath stay even.

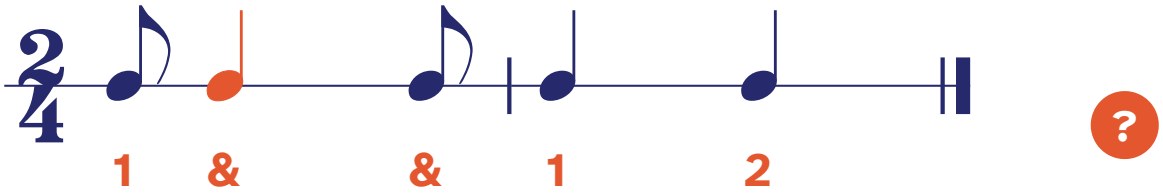
PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

Syncopation Level 4

A note starts on the “&”, between the beats, and is held through the next beat. Feel that beat even though nothing is played on it.

EXAMPLE 2

Where does the long note start?
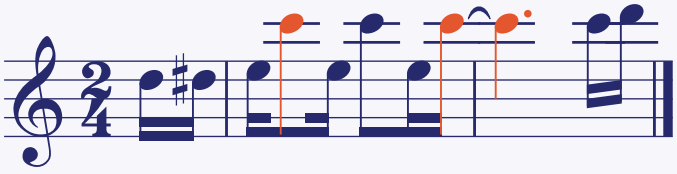


1. **Tap the beats:** 1, 2.
2. **Find the red crotchet.** Does it start on a beat, or on the “&”?
3. **Hold it:** through which beat?

It starts on the “&” and holds through beat 2: the long note starts **off the beat**. That is syncopation.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Entertainer (Scott Joplin)



The high **C** keeps landing just after the beat, not on it: syncopation, the bounce of ragtime.

Try it. Tap the beat with your foot and hum the tune: hear the C slip between the taps.

THINK OF IT Syncopation is a skip in your walk: a step that lands between the beats.

HOW TO

Feel off-beat rhythm

1. **Tap a steady beat** with your foot.
2. **Clap only between the taps**, on the “&”.
3. **If the foot starts to follow the hands,** slow down.

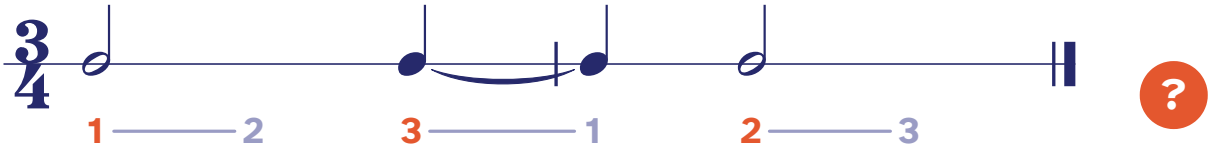
PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

Hemiola Level 4

Two bars of 3/4 felt as three bars of two: three minims across the bar line. Common at the ends of phrases in Baroque dances.

EXAMPLE 3

Two bars of 3, or one big bar?



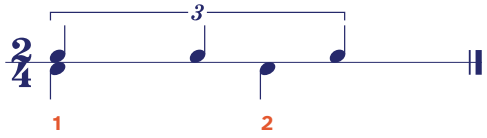
1. **Count as written:** "1 2 3, 1 2 3".
2. **Look at the notes:** how many beats does each minim last?
3. **Feel each minim** as one big beat. How many big beats?

Three minims of two beats: the six beats are felt as **three big ones**. That is a hemiola.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Polyrhythm and rubato

Polyrhythm (Level 7): two rhythms at once.



Three against two: a triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato: Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much music from the 1800s.



TRAP

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Swinging the crotchets: only the quaver pairs swing.

SEE ALSO

Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65 · Words for how to play: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Rhythm clock